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The Return of THE KING

Humayun's action-packed life, reimagined as a medieval romp, with a few battles thrown in

| By Gillian Wright |

Edward Rutherford is a successful historical novelist from Salisbury in the UK but Alex Rutherford, the author of this particular novel, is not, as you might think, in any way related. He is in fact not one but two people—the husband and wife team of Diana and Michael Preston. Diana already has an impressive list of history books to her credit, but perhaps the most successful was the one she wrote with her husband under this pseudonym about Babur. This novel, the second in a series they plan on the Mughals, is devoted to his son and successor Humayun.

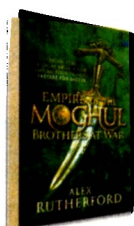
Mughal lives are packed with drama and adventure. The authors have drawn on contemporary sources such as the works of Humayun's sister Gulbadan, but readers should remember that this is a novel and in many places the authors have

preferred fiction to fact. Humayun's brother Hindal suffers the worst in the fictionalised parts of the story. He dies a miserable death in the wilderness, rather than fighting beside Humayun. The infant Akbar, who in the novel is snatched from his parents by Humayun's dastardly brother Kamran, was in fact left behind to be cared for by another brother Askari. He looked after Akbar well despite being a leader of the opposing faction, illustrating the Timurid code of honour. Humayun did hand over the Koh-e-Noor to the Persian ruler, but in an ornate jewel box, rather than from a bag around his neck as described in the book.

The authors specialise in action, and the plot bowls along at a fast pace. Every battle is exciting, and even though we know roughly what happens next, the authors do create suspense. The characters are well-drawn, but don't sound particularly Indian or Turkish or Persian. Instead they seem at once modern and universally medieval, struggling with concepts of honour, statecraft and clan loyalty. You feel the authors would recount the battles of King Arthur in more or less the same way. Humayun himself comes across as brave, chivalrous, never shirking a battle, but also inordinately sentimental where his brothers are concerned, forgiving them for treachery after treachery.

Humayun's love of opium and addiction to astrology are shown as the other means of his undoing. A flawed personality is always fascinating and despite omitting entertaining details such as the fleeing monarch being reduced to eating horse flesh boiled in a helmet, his roller coaster ride from riches to rags to riches is compelling. In the novel, Humayun rarely foregoes sex even before battles. These exploits seem remarkable for a man who produced only one male heir and that too at the age of 34. At least one historian has suggested that a reason for both Humayun and Akbar's lack of heirs may be that the Mughals gave less importance to sex than the conventional portrait of the oriental despot would have us believe. But Rutherford is happy to keep Humayun in despot mould, and hopelessly romantic at that, falling in love at first sight with his wife Hamida when she is just 14.

The women in the novel, as is to be expected in today's context and as also seems to have been the case, are portrayed as highly educated, commanding figures. Humayun's aunt Khanzada slaps him repeatedly across the face to recall him from his opium-induced slumber and Hamida travels with him throughout his direst days. While the Prestons' Mughals are puppets in their hands, by avoiding straight biography they have turned their lives into sterling bestseller stuff. ■



EMPIRE OF THE MOGHUL: BROTHERS AT WAR
by ALEX RUTHERFORD
Hachette India
Price: Rs 495
Pages: 436